

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

JIMMY CARTER 1924-2024



AS CITIZEN, A SINGULAR EX-PRESIDENCY

From feeling adrift after Oval Office to becoming a beacon

By Sheryl Gay Stolber | The New York Times

President Jimmy Carter had no idea what he was going to do next when he delivered his farewell address to the nation in January 1981. Defeated after a single term by Ronald Reagan, he simply told Americans that he would leave the White House and “take up once more the only title in our democracy superior to that of president — the title of citizen.”

Nearly 44 years later, there is little question among historians that Citizen Carter carved a new mold for life after the Oval Office and that his post-presidency was the most consequential in modern history. But his impact was felt more strongly overseas than at home — especially in the realm of public health.

One of Carter’s biggest and most lasting post-presidential accomplishments is also one of the most overlooked: the near total eradication of Guinea worm disease, a painful parasitic

infection for which there is no treatment or vaccine. In 1986, it afflicted an estimated 3.5 million people, mostly in Africa and Asia. There were only seven reported cases through the first 10 months of 2024, according to the Carter Center, Carter’s human rights organization.

Carter first saw the devastating effects of the disease in 1988, in two villages near Accra, Ghana. “Once you’ve seen a small child with a 2- or 3-foot-long live Guinea worm protruding from her body, right through her skin, you never forget it,” he later wrote in *The Washington Post*.

Carter wrote books, 32 in all, and devoted his energies to advancing global health, democracy and human rights. He won the Nobel Peace Prize in 2002. He once said the world’s biggest problem was violence against women and girls, and he cited religious texts as a leading cause. He helped ensure free and fair

Turn to Carter, Page 9

Above: Former President Jimmy Carter and former first lady Rosalyn Carter help administer praziquantel pills for schistosomiasis in Nigeria on Feb. 15, 2007. The Carter Center, instrumental in battling Guinea worm and other neglected diseases across the globe, also launched a campaign against schistosomiasis. **WES POPE/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Chicago to see hikes in taxes, fines, fees

Mix of increases fill out city’s final budget plan for next year

By Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson and aldermen got their 2025 city budget passed just under the wire — and just in time for Chicagoans to start paying more as the calendar flips to 2025 for the host of tax, fine and fee increases the city’s political leaders picked to balance the books.

The chaotic budget battle had its hard lines. Johnson refused to lower spending via broad layoffs and service cuts, and aldermen refused his property tax hike proposals.

So the city’s new spending plan finally came together in large part thanks to a series of smaller — and, theoretically, less politically toxic — hikes expected to bring in nearly \$200 million next year. That bill is widespread, targeting everything from Netflix subscriptions and corporate cloud computing to drivers caught speeding by cameras and pedicab licenses.

“It was a matter of catching up in industries and other major cities,” said Johnson ally Ald. William Hall, 6th. “Chicago has to keep up with inflation, increases in industry costs and residential needs. And to do that, it costs money.”

The fee, fine and tax buffet City Hall settled on wasn’t the original plan. Johnson first proposed closing the city’s budget gap with a \$300 million property tax increase. Aldermen quickly shot down the idea and then rejected two smaller property tax hikes Johnson also sought.

The mix City Hall settled on included a final batch of \$23.6

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MICHAEL MADIGAN TRIAL

Accountant, former IRS worker eyed by defense

Attempt to show Solis allegedly cheated on taxes while cooperating

By Jason Meisner and Megan Crepeau
Chicago Tribune

Lawyers for former House Speaker Michael Madigan want the jury in his corruption trial to see evidence that then-Ald. Daniel Solis allegedly cheated on his taxes while cooperating undercover with the federal government.

Madigan’s lawyers said in court Monday they want to call Solis’ longtime accountant as well as a former IRS employee to testify about the then-alderman’s tax returns, which the defense has alleged failed to claim hundreds of thousands of dollars in payments Solis received from his sister.

Madigan’s legal team began putting on their case Dec. 19 before a long holiday break, but the identities of their upcoming witnesses had not been discussed in full on the public record.

The revelation came before what was supposed to be a lengthy hearing about which legal instructions the judge should read to jurors before they deliberate. That never got off

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One paddle at a time

Volunteer guides forge bonds to Chicago River’s rich history and ecology

By Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

Marvin Fournier launched two canoes off a city park boat dock on a recent December afternoon, as he has done countless times for over a decade. The vessels were decked out in twinkling Christmas lights, the remnants of a prior paddling outing on the river — a holiday tradition with fellow river canoe guides.

“We put up Christmas trees and decorations, and we went on the main stem,” he recalled. “We sang songs, and people were singing from the bridges with us. It was incredible.”

Fournier discovered the magic of the river 15 years ago when he started leading canoe trips with Friends of the Chicago River. He’s one of several volunteer guides underpinning the nonprofit’s efforts to increase accessibility and share love for the river.

Because they are all volunteers, Fournier added, “there’s no ego.” The organization’s executive director, Margaret Frisbie, can attest to that.

“The first time I met Marvin, he said, ‘You know, I’d pay to do this.’

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BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Pucks flying around Wrigley

Blackhawks left wing Nick Foligno greets people during practice on the Wrigley Field ice Monday before facing the Blues in the NHL Winter Classic on Tuesday. Wrigley Field hosted the Classic on New Year’s Day 2009, with the Hawks losing to the Wings 6-4. **Chicago Sports**

Ald. Gardiner settles First Amendment lawsuit

Ald. Jim Gardiner, 45th, has agreed to pay more than \$157,000 to settle a lawsuit filed by six Northwest Side residents. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

South Korea calls for Boeing inspections

South Korean officials say that they will conduct safety inspections of Boeing aircraft operated by the country’s airlines. **Nation & World**

TODAY’S WEATHER



High 41 Low 26

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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